Southern magnolia (bull bay)

Magnolia grandiflora

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Overlook: 3 **TOTAL 3**



Summer / form
Library candidate

Not available

Fall color
Not available



Flower
Library candidate



Leaf close-up
Library candidate

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Evergreen
Mature size: 60–80 ft (to 80 ft or more) × 20–40 ft (to 30–50 ft; pyramidal to rounded crown)
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Hardy in USDA zones 6a–10b (commonly 7A–10A), including 8a and 8b. Native to the southeastern United States coastal plain and bottomlands, including Georgia. Heat and humidity tolerant. Suitable for Atlanta Zone 8a.
Sun: Full sun to partial shade
Water: Prefers moist; moderate drought tolerance once established (higher with ample root space).
Soil: Good drainage, moist, rich, acidic preferred; adapts to clay, loam, slightly alkaline, occasionally wet.
Growth rate: Moderate / medium.
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: (Care / planting pass): Plant at grade in full sun to partial shade (partial shade preferred if irrigation limited early). Prefers rich, moist, well-drained, acidic soil; tolerates clay, slightly alkaline, wet. Wide-spreading roots (up to 4× canopy); give ample space. Prune after flowering or as needed to remove dead/weak/narrow-crotch branches; little pruning required for structure. Check and cut circling/girdling roots at planting. First-year irrigation: adequate watering during first season recommended; Not stated in detail beyond general establishment. Mulch depth, mound vs level, soil amendment: Not stated.
Soil prep: Good drainage, moist, rich, acidic preferred; adapts to clay, loam, slightly alkaline, occasionally wet.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Native to the southeastern U.S. coastal plain (North Carolina/South Carolina to central Florida, west to eastern Texas). Described by Linnaeus in 1759. Seed introduced to England by Mark Catesby in 1726. Widely cultivated and naturalized beyond the original range. [Flora of North America; UF/IFAS; Silvics of North America]
Form / habit: Broadleaf evergreen, large pyramidal to rounded dense crown; lower branches often to the ground; long-lived.
Foliage: Not stated (evergreen; older leaves shed as new growth emerges).
Flowers / fruit: Large (8–12 in), fragrant, creamy white, saucer-shaped, late spring to summer.
Bark / stem: Smooth gray when young; develops scaly plates with age.
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: (Health / infestation pass): Mostly problem-free; resistant to pests/diseases. Occasional issues: magnolia scale (most common; can cause honeydew and sooty mold), other scales, tulip-poplar weevil, magnolia borer on young stock, leaf spots, blights, cankers (prune out), algal leaf spot. Verticillium wilt susceptibility noted (may kill branches or rarely the tree). Provide stress-free conditions; water in dry weather.